



5 Gyres Executive Director Position Description

Position Title: Executive Director

Status: Full-Time, Exempt

Location: Hybrid/Remote (West Coast preferred; open to exceptional candidates elsewhere)

Travel: Requires up to 40% travel

Reports To: The 5 Gyres Board of Directors

Salary: \$130,000 - \$150,000 (commensurate with experience)

Application Deadline: January 30, 2026

Ideal Start Date: Late March or early April 2026 (flexible)

About The 5 Gyres Institute

The 5 Gyres Institute is a pioneering nonprofit organization at the forefront of the global fight against plastic pollution. For over a decade, we have driven breakthrough science, policy change, and public awareness to address one of the most urgent environmental and public health crises of our time.

With plastic production projected to triple by 2060 and microplastics now found in every ecosystem and the human body, the need for bold, science-driven solutions has never been greater. Our work has influenced major policy wins, advanced groundbreaking research on microplastics, and mobilized communities worldwide.

With a current, projected annual budget of \$1.7 million and a dedicated team with strong scientific credibility, we are poised to dramatically scale our impact at the precise moment when the world is waking up to the plastic crisis.

Our Core Values: Science • Collaboration • Impact

The Opportunity

This is a rare opportunity to lead a respected, science-driven organization through its next chapter of growth and influence.

We are seeking a visionary, courageous Executive Director to guide 5 Gyres into its next phase, doubling organizational capacity and impact over the next five years. You will work closely with the Board of Directors, lead a talented interdisciplinary team, and position 5 Gyres as one of the preeminent authorities on plastic pollution solutions globally.

This role is ideal for a leader who thrives at the intersection of science, policy, fundraising, and movement-building, and who is ready to help shape the future of plastic pollution solutions.

Who You Are

We seek a leader who embodies:

- **Deep expertise** in plastic pollution, environmental advocacy, or related fields
 - **Entrepreneurial vision** with a track record of scaling organizations or initiatives
 - **Collaborative spirit** that empowers teams and builds coalitions
 - **Political savvy** to navigate complex policy environments and industry opposition
 - **Communication excellence** that translates complex science for diverse audiences
 - **Deep commitment** to science-based solutions and environmental justice
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Key Responsibilities

1. Strategic Leadership & Vision

- Lead the development and execution of a 5-year strategy to double organizational impact and revenue (from ~\$1.7M to \$3–3.4M)
- Define what “doubling impact” means: policies enacted, systems changed, harm reduced
- Position 5 Gyres at the forefront of emerging science, policy, and advocacy opportunities
- Represent the organization in national and international forums, including UN convenings and stakeholder coalitions

2. Fundraising & Strategic Partnerships

- Engage high-level partners and funders by translating technical and policy work into compelling cases for support
- Identify and expand opportunities for mission-aligned projects and partnerships
- Explore and develop earned-income opportunities that support 5 Gyres’ mission

3. Science, Policy & Advocacy Leadership

- Champion 5 Gyres' scientific integrity and ensure excellence + credibility
- Guide advocacy strategies that translate science into policy wins at local, state, national, and global levels
- Build relationships with key policymakers, agency staff, and legislative champions

4. Board Governance & Leadership

- Work closely with the Board on strategy, direction, and governance
 - Support board development by identifying and recruiting needed skills and perspectives
 - Enable the board to fulfill fiduciary responsibilities through transparent financial reporting, risk management updates, and compliance assurance
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Qualifications

Required

- At least 10 years of senior leadership experience in the environmental field
- Demonstrated success in fundraising and partnership development
- Experience working with and supporting a Board of Directors
- Strong financial and organizational management skills
- Exceptional written and verbal communication abilities

Strongly Preferred

- Experience influencing public policy or regulatory outcomes
 - Background of training in science, research, or high-stakes advocacy
 - Crisis communications or rapid-response experience
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Compensation & Benefits

- Salary: \$130,000–\$150,000
 - Comprehensive benefits package including health insurance and generous PTO
 - Flexible hybrid/remote work environment
 - Professional development support
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To Apply

Interested applicants should send the following to careers@5gyres.org: by January 30th, 2026

- Resume
 - Cover Letter
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Not the right role for you, but know someone who would be a great fit? [Referrals are warmly welcomed.](#)

5 Gyres Commitment to Diversity: *5 Gyres is an Equal Opportunity Employer. We are committed to ensuring an equitable, just, diverse, and inclusive work environment for all, without regard to race, color, religion, gender, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, family or parental status, national origin, genetics, disability, age, or veteran status.*